MERRILL LYNCH: BOB SMITH (your partner, your boss, your associate, etc.) asked me to give you a call. He thought you might be interested in some of the strategies we're using to (reduce taxes, increase the return on your investments, make money in the market, etc.). Choose one.

KING LEAR: Nothing will come of nothing, speak again. . . .

MERRILL LYNCH: I've been speaking to attorneys in the area about ways to reduce their taxes and increase their income.

KING LEAR: How now! Mend your speech a little lest you may mar your fortunes. . . .

MERRILL LYNCH: I can understand the need to be cautious, and that's why an investment offering safety of principle might be appropriate.

By the third day, I'd almost lost all desire to become a stockbroker. First, I discovered my deficiencies in drama. Then I found out that brokers aren't allowed to open their own mail. Anything that's sent to the office, even a love letter, is scissored by the bosses, who are looking for cash or checks that might otherwise elude the firm's grasp. On top of that, the average broker spent most of his waking hours calling up strangers. This "cold calling" was a familiar feature of the business, but I had no idea how much time it consumed. According to the sample schedule handed out at Merrill Lynch, a broker was expected to spend five hours during three workdays a week plus another hour and fifteen minutes on two extra weeknights dialing for new customers. The minimum recommended effort was 180 cold calls every Monday through Friday.

To find enough new people to call, the broker was encouraged to seek out prospective clients from lists of survivors in obituary columns, from articles about the beneficiaries of large legal settlements, from telephone books in fancy neighborhoods, and from specialized mailing lists. A catalog of lists handed out at Merrill Lynch mentioned: "1.1 Million Affluent Individuals," "Aircraft Pilots at Home with Telephone Numbers," "Arabs Who Gamble and Invest," "Cattle and New Movie Investors," "Blue-chip Stockholders," and "Dentists Who Are Heavy Investors."

At Prudential-Bache, they said forget dentists. Dentists weren't